Ninth Life

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

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by lologoblens

Summary

A Magicat gets nine chances, nine lives to find their soulmate before their mark fades forever. The only way to know how many lives you've lived is to reach your ninth life and be born without a soulmark. Catra isn't worried, for one thing she has an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. For another, she thinks it's all bullshit anyway. And even if she is born without a soulmark in her next life, well that's not her current self's issue, now is it?

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Bottom of the E ghth

One

Ana & Camilla

Ana couldnt *take* it anymore;the constant abuse, the sweet apologies the nekxday , promises that it was all for her best interests. It wasnt, at sikteen she was old enough now to know the dif ference. She spent months doing odd jobs around the neighborhood;selling pot she got from the senior in her math class to her friends, and anything else she could think of to scrape together enough cash for a bus ticket and at least a few weeks of food. The bus left at 4 AM the nekxmorning. She was barely able to contain her nerves at dinner that night. When Lnette asked her about it as they got ready for bed, she brushed it off. She mentioned slyly that the house Matriarch, Sharon, *had a word with her* earlier. They all knew what that meant. It wasnt true, not this time, but it made Lnette back of f. As soon as she heard her roommates' snores, she was out the window, never to return.

Of course, if Isolde had just *waited*, even just twelve hours, she would have met Camilla. Sharon's newest foster child, a magicat who had an identical mark to Ana;an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. As it was, she didnt have anyone to run with.

Two

Catherine & Abigail

Catherine lingered in the window of the shop, admiring the new display, her tail flicking behind her. One jacket in particular had caught her eye, maroon and sleek in design;the design look like it was either from or inspired by the current fashions in Milan. Catherine's ears flicked behind her, a group of teens was coming her way. She scurried off, it's not like should could afford *anything* in that shop anyway. She imagines what it might be like, if she had somewhere to go where that sort of attire would be appropriate. But it's just a daydream, Catherine will never go into that shop. It would only make her sad.

Of course, if Catherine *had* gone into that shop, that day or nearly any other, she would have met Abigail. The seamstress's assistant who had an identical mark to Catherine;an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. As it was, she never found out how good wearing that jacket would feel.

Three

Angelina & Caitlin

Angelina hates dancing. They swear it up, down and sideways. They aren't coordinated enough, their limbs lanky and awkward. But after tonight, well… Angelina still hates dancing *sober*. But just for tonight, she's having fun. Out with all of her friends, glitter coming at her from every angle and a disco ball lighting up the scene, she feels free. Light and happy. Then she catches the eye of the tall, dark and handsome magic… at across the room, standing at the bar. She stares, too drunk to be abashed. They catch her eye, smile and wink. Angelina's friends don't miss the interaction, which is surprising seeing as they're at least as drunk as she is. They *beg* her to go to the bar. Buy the woman a drink, offer her number, *something*, anything! She doesn't, she convinces herself it's because she doesn't have time to date right now anyway. Not while she chases that promotion at work.

Of course, if Angelina had been just *braver*, they would have hit it off. She would have found out that the woman's name was Caitlin and she had an identical mark to Angelina: an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. As it was Angelina went home alone, ignoring the feeling that lingered in her gut for *months* after that night that told her she had missed an important opportunity.

Four

Charlie & Anabella

Charlie was late, they were always late! Jogging lightly toward the subway stop they checked their watch. Who were they kidding, they were never going to catch the next train! They slowed their pace significantly, texting their boss that that they would be late. *Again*. Their tail wrapped around their leg defeatedly, ears flattening against their head. It was a good thing Stacy was so forgiving, otherwise they'd have been fired ages ago. They knew they ought to not take advantage but well the snooze but is always a wicked temptress in the morning. Already late they figured they might as well get a coffee after all, maybe something to butter up Stacy too.

Of course, if Charlie had been just a *bit* more persistent, they easily could have caught that train. It was delayed by twelve minutes. Then, they would have met Anabella who was sitting next to the only free seat on the train and had an identical mark to Charlie: an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. As it was, they got the coffee, but not their soulmate.

Five

Anastasia & Charity

This wasn't right, it couldn't be! There was no way Anastasia *didn't* get into Yale. *Waitlisted* is *not* the same thing as getting in. And after all of her hard work over the last four years. What was it all even for? Well, sure she'd gotten into several of their backups, and Columbia wasn't a terrible school. But still! And she certainly wasn't going to wait around on some stupid *waitlist*. It was insulting, if they didn't want her, they couldn't have her. She shredded the letter and never thought about the stupid school again.

Of course, if Anastasia had been even a little *patient*, things would have gone very differently. For one thing, she would have had a different roommate; Charity, a magicat who grew up just two towns over from her and had an identical mark to Anastasia: an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. As it was Anastasia graduated with a degree in Political Science from Columbia University and Charity graduated magna cum laude from Yale the same year with a degree in Astrophysics. The two women never met.

Six

Chance & Adam

Chance hadn't a hope of passing this biology class. It was too hard! And their teacher, Dr. Weeden, *definitely* had it out for him. It wasn't his fault he'd sassed her in the first lesson; she's the one who shouldn't have passed out a syllabus so riddled with typos! Natasha, his advisor, nearly begged them to just get a tutor already. He needed he needed this class for his major. He knew it was inevitable, but he'd put it off, just for one more day. Enzo and Stasia were having a movie night in their dorm and he still had an English paper to finish if he was gonna make time to go. Well that, and a nap to take, but whatever. He was *tired* and he wasn't exactly gonna be able to take in information about the powerhouse of the cell if he was dead on his feet, right?

Of course, if Chance hadn't been so *stubborn*, he would have gotten assigned a different tutor then he did the following day. Adam would have helped him get a full letter grade higher in his class and eventually he would have learned they had an identical mark to Chance: an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above their breastbone. As it was Chance had to retake biology the following quarter.

Seven

Alice & Carla

Alice was so tired, she hated working bar hours, but the tips were too good to turn her back on. Today just *really* wasn't her day; she started her period early with cramps to match and had closed her fingers in the drawer when she pulled out the Midol. It was decided, she was begging off work tonight. Horace would have to find some other shmuck to work, she didn't have it in her to care how many demerits he gave her. She was eating ice cream and watching stupid movies and crying with her face snuggled into her dog's fur. And that was that.

Of course, if she'd been honest with herself about just how much she *needed* those tips, she would have gone in. And one of her first customers of the night would have been Carla, a feisty magicat in a crimson, low-cut top who had an identical mark to Alice: an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. As it was, she stayed in and drowned her sorrows in a pint and a half of Cherry Garcia.

Eight

Clarissa & Andrea

"Mama! Would you back off? I'm only twenty-eight, I still have plenty of time to find somebody."

"Not just somebody, Clarissa! I'm talking about your *soulmate* baby. And I know you're young, and it feels like you have all the time in the world. But Clarissa, you know magicats only get- "

"Nine chances, nine lives to find their soulmate before their mark fades forever. *Yes* mama, I've heard the legends plenty of times. From you actually. And even if they are true, there's no way to know how many lives you've lived; I could only be on my second for all you know!"

"Not *just* legends, and a mother always knows. I know you're young baby girl, but I think you're running out of chances. A mother's intuition is always worth trusting." Clarissa rolls her eyes; how many times has she heard *that* before?

"I know, I know mama. But you never know where you could meet your soulmate, right?"

Mama rolls her eyes. "Eh, I think it's a pretty safe bet you're not going to meet him working in that cubicle where you see the same people day after day!" Clarissa winces imperceptibly. *Hm*. If it's a him Clarissa would rather take her chances and wait until her next lifetime.

"Alright, fine, you have a point. But I still need to go right now. I promised my boss I'd have this project done by Monday. Saturday or not, I don't have time this weekend to go out mingling with the young

people. I have to work.”Mama spends another ten minutes lecturing her before Clarissa manages to get out the door.

Of course, if Clarissa had listened to her *own* advice maybe things would have gone differently. Maybe she wouldnt have stuck earbuds in the moment she sat at her desk, then she would have noticed the tall blond facilities worker in the corner. She would have found out that her name was Andrea and she had an identical mark to Clarissa: an oddly shaped, heart-like image imprinted above her breastbone. As it was, Clarissa got a promotion but lost her penultimate chance at her soulmate.

Top of the Ninth

Nine
Adora & Catra

One

Adora stands in the changing room, inspecting herself in the dress. She rubs her fingers over the strange heart that rests on her breastbone and sighs. All of her friends tell her how *lucky* she is. Her soulmark can be so easily made visible, and it's *pretty*. A fairly uncommon combo which theoretically makes her soulmate much easier to find. She wears a lot of button ups. Much to her friends' dismay.

Adora isn't really sure what her hang up is. Maybe it's how inorganic it feels. You meet someone, have this arbitrary thing in common, and you're just supposed to take the universe's word for it? There are so many things that could go wrong she doesn't even know where to begin! Plus, she could have more than one soulmate to contend with. She met someone once who had *three*. Granted they were always poly, but still, it opens up a whole other world of *what if's*. The idea of *one* soulmate relationship makes her feel like she's drifting off in space, trying to fight her way back to earth even as she drifts further away. What the heck would she do with *three*?

She looks at herself in the dress again. She's never gonna wear it with her mark showing so clearly. She huffs, it's too bad; the dress *is* really flattering... It doesn't matter. She starts getting redressed in her own clothes.

Catra eyes herself in the mirror, checking herself out. She leaves her tie untied and her top few shirt buttons left undone. Whether she buys into the whole soulmark thing or not, hers *is* pretty cool. Like

some futuristic, techy heart. She rubs her fingers across it, ruffling the soft fur on her chest slightly. It makes her mark less defined but helps with the overall effect she's going for. Someone huffs in the changing room next to her , she glances at the shared wall briefly then goes back to checking herself out. Yeah, thisll do nicely .

She looks at the pile of clothes she hasnt tried on yet. She wont be buying any other clothes today, cant really af ford to. She could be done, but what the hell, right? Never hurts the ego to see yourself looking hot in clothes youll likely never buy . She's throwing on a sleek jumpsuit when the shared wall rattles as the other person' s door falls shut.

Looking back at the mirror she decides maybe she has *just enough* pennies to scrape together. She might buy the jumpsuit too…

Two

Adora loves getting assigned to the blue line, there's so many pretty tree lined streets and well-tended gardens. It's much more scenic than getting stuck on the red line, circling through the city for eight hours. She still goes through downtown, but just to the bus depot where a lot of the busses connect, then she's express until she reaches the more residential area. She finishes her first loop, running on schedule which leaves her plenty of time for a quick trip to the bus depot bathroom. A little while later she pulls away, right on time, and is on her way. The bus is pretty empty this time of day and by the time she's out of the city she's a few minutes ahead of schedule. A few folks get on at the corner of Bright Moon Way and 55th and she waits to move on until they find seats. She's just pulling away when she hears someone shouting.

"Hold! Fucking shit!" Adora's eyes flick to her side mirror to see a distraught looking woman slow from a run to a jog just past the bus stop. Adora breaks and opens the door again. A few seconds later the woman climbs on, looking like she could cry from relief. "Holy stars, *thank you*. You truly saved my ass." She pants as she slides cash into the machine.

She's freaking gorgeous; hair in a tousled ponytail between soft looking ears, immaculately winged eyeliner framing heterochromatic eyes, and a smile so dangerous Adora already feels like she's in trouble. "Right." She gets out slowly. "Of course."

Catra crams her bills into the machine, watching them get sucked up. "Holy stars, *thank you*. You truly saved my ass." She tells the driver as she struggles to catch her breath. And truly they did. Catra *wants* this job. If she'd been late to the interview because she spent too much time redoing her eyeliner, she wouldn't have ever been able to forgive herself.

"Right." The driver says after a pause. Catra looks up, she's fucking hot. Soft grey eyes that make Catra think of being inside on a stormy day, a kind smile, and a high and tight ponytail so perfect it makes her wants to mess up just to see how flustered it would make this woman. "Of course."

Catra smiles at her and takes the proffered transfer ticket from a shaking hand. Catra looks at it for a moment, then her eyes trail up an impressively buff looking arm and back to the driver's face. "Thanks." She thinks about asking for her name but, well this poor woman's at work. Catra doesnt want to hassle her. Besides, she should be going over her portfolio one more time.

The bus pulls away but Catra makes no move to open her bag. She just keeps watching the driver, enjoying the warm smiles she gives to people getting on and off the bus. Each smile makes Catra feel like she's wrapped in a warm blanket on a sunny afternoon. She sort of hates how much she likes it. It's stupid anyway, Catra's going to get off this bus, go to this interview, and probably never see this woman again. Her tail flicks in agitation at the thought. It doesnt matter.

Three

When the stunning magicat woman had gotten off at the bus depot that day Adora assumed she'd never see her again. Nowwell now she wonders if she'd gotten a new job or something. She gets on at the bus depot every weekday evening with the third wave of commuter's when the bus is a little less packed. She has a bus pass now, so there's no reason for her to linger at the front. But sometimes she shoots Adora a wink as she gets on. It makes her heart ache to swoon but Adora fights it. It's hard to drive a bus if you're too busy swooning.

Catra officially has a crush on her bus driver. Not the kooky old woman she sees most mornings, whose name is Razas Catra learns after a couple weeks. She always asks Catra how her Mara is doing. Catra doesnt know a Mara but she gives up on trying to tell Razthat after a week. It' s the bus driver Catra sees in the evenings who's captured her attention. As she noted the first time she caught her bus, the woman is fucking hot. She also never lets up with the kind smiles and stormy eyes. Catra wonders what she's like when she's having a bad day, if she ever does.

She's also adorably easy to fluster. It's fairly busy when Catra gets on the bus now, even though she hangs back to let the first couple waves of people get out of the way. So, she doesnt exactly have time to pause and flirt. She does, however, send her the occasional wink which never fails to get the bus driver blushing up a storm. And every night when Catra hops off the bus she calls back, "Goodnight!" It quickly becomes a part of Catra' s routine that she's not sure she ever wants to have to live without.

Four

Catra hates the beach. The sand gets stuck in her fur and itches and she's *hardly* a fan of swimming. Why couldnt Scorpia and her girlfriend have chosen a nice indoor activity to introduce their friends to each other over? And why the fuck was Scorpia so nervous anyway? They were *soft* for goodness' sakes! Wasnt their love supposed to be able to overcome all odds? Catra hardly thought the lecture disguised as a simple request was necessary. Catra may hate sweating in what was essentially a giant litter box situated next to her literal worst fear, but she wasnt gonna embarrass her best friend. Frankly Entrapta ought to be considered more of a concern, at least in her opinion.

So, she shows up, swimsuit on under her tank and shorts and ready to contend with the beach. There's already a group of six people spread across a couple blankets with snacks littered between them. Catra draws closer and stops short when she gets close enough to see their faces. Well, well, well, if it isnt Catra's Bff Adora. Suddenly Catra is *much* more interested in being here.

"Scorpia! Hey!" She calls with a wave as she closes the distance between the group and herself. She doesnt miss the way Bow and Adora's eyes widen when she looks up to determine the source of the voice. She smirks, this should be a *fun* day.

"Scorpia! Hey!" They all hear called from a couple meters away. Adora looks up and her eyes widen as she freezes. She doesnt even hear what Scorpia says, the sound filling her ears makes her feel like Bow is holding a shell against each, insisting there are tiny oceans inside them. She looks over at him and Glimmer and cuts her eyes to the newcomer with a significant look. They shake their heads and shoot confused glances her way.

“Hey everyone!” Scorpia calls the groups attention, cutting off Adora’s attempt to communicate her dilemma to her friends. “This is my very best friend in the whole wide world.” Scorpia’s friend fidgets at the compliment and subsequent attention. “Catra, these are Perfuma’s friends; that’s Sea Hawk, Bow, Glimmer, Adora and oh-hey, wasn’t Mermista just here?”

Sea Hawk clears his throat. “Ah, my dear Mermista cannot be kept from the sea for long I’m afraid. But if you hop in the water, I’m sure you’ll be fast friends!”

Catra’s ears flick, Adora smiles at the name and at the little scowl on her face. “Yeah, that’s not fucking happening. I’m sure I’ll meet her at some point though.”

Scorpia swoops in to explain. “Ah, yes Catra isn’t much of a swimmer, *but* there’s so many fun things to do on land! We’re gonna have a great day.”

Adora watches Catra flick her tail in short movements and barely manage to suppress a roll of her eyes. “Yeah, whatever. Entrapta late again?”

Scorpia laughs jovially. “You know that she is. She texted me that she was on her way a half hour ago, so she’ll probably leave in another twenty minutes or so.” They chuckle like this is some sort of shared joke. Adora reminds herself of the mark Scorpia and Perfuma share, a small succulent resting against a succulent on their inner ankles, in an effort to stamp down the irrational jealousy that threatens to claw it’s was out of her chest.

Suddenly Catra drops her bag a foot away from Adora and the magicat follows right after. “So, Adora huh?” She asks as she settles in.

“Uh, yeah, hi. It’s um, nice to like meet you, meet you.” Catra laughs and the sound tickles at Adora’s gut.

"Yeah, you too."

"Sorry, do you two *know* each other?" Bow cuts in.

"Yeah, Adora, what? Are you making friends without us?" Glimmer fake pouts.

"Oh um, Catra here rides my route ah...sometimes." She gives them another look. Their eyes widen in recognition, finally deducing what Adora's strange looks were trying to indicate earlier.

"Oh, *ooh*!" Bow says eloquently.

"Yeah, uh by the way, thanks for stopping that first day. I was sure I was gonna miss my interview."

"Oh, so you did get a new job?" Adora says unthinkingly. Catra looks at her strangely, *a bit*.

"Oh, so you did get a new job?" Now how the hell did she know that when she didn't even know Catra's name a few minutes ago? "Sorry! I just noticed um...you're part of my commuter crowd in the evenings now."

"Ah." Understanding dawns and Catra smirks. "So...you noticed me in the big ol' crowd?" She goes for innocent; she doubts it works. It's well worth the blush Adora breaks out in.

"Um, well sure, I just uh...did, yeah." Catra laughs and reaches for them hem of her tank, pulling it over her head. If she's here, she might as well get some color. She hears Glimmer gasp as she tosses it aside but thinks nothing of it, turning to root in her back for sunblock.

"Adora!" Glimmer hisses. Catra looks up to see Adora staring at chest, her eyes wide. She's mostly flattered, but also a little

uncomfortable. Something about Adora's look makes her feel vulnerable, too exposed.

She goes for bravado. "Hey, my eyes are up here toots."

Adora's eyes dart to hers and she flushes all the way down her neck. "Oh, s-sorry!" She's reduced to a stuttering mess. It makes Catra preen just a bit. "Uh, I didn't mean any dis- I, it's just your mark."

"Oh." Catra looks down to inspect it for herself. Sometimes her mark *does* get a reaction. It's decently large for a soulmark and certainly striking. Still though, Adora's reaction is pretty strong. "Yeah, had it my whole life."

Adora smiles but it doesn't reach her eyes. "It's um... nice. Does it… do you know what it means?"

Catra looks down again, furrowing her brow. "Means? I think it's just like... a weird design honestly."

"Oh, uhm... well I mean I'm sure you know more about your own mark that a perfect stranger. I mean, I don't know a lot about it," Catra vaguely registers Glimmer snorting and being shushed by, fuck what was his name? Arrow, Aaron? Doesn't really matter, she'll figure it out. "but it *looks* kind of like, maybe, first one's writing?"

Catra quirks a brow. "What, that old dead language or whatever?" It was sort of funny she said that. Entrapta *had* told her that the symbol reminded her of some of the imagery she found on the ancient tech she researched. She'd brushed it off though, just assumed it was Entrapta trying to bring another conversation back to her research. "Can you read that shit?"

"Uh... sort of?"

"Sort of?" Bow repeats indignantly, Catra raises a brow at him in question. "Adora you've spent so long in my dads' library researching it you should have an honorary degree by now."

"Is that so?" Catra turns to look at Adora again. "So?" At Adora's confused glance she huffs and clarifies. "What does it mean then?"

"Ohum, well sometimes it can mean heart." Catra snorts, she probably could have figured *that* out. But then Adora's expression goes soft and she tilts her head, her eyes piercing Catra's. "Usually though, it means'… safety'. Um specifically it refers to the sense of safety provided by love and the trust that comes with it." That sobers Catra, for a minute the only sound coming from their group is Perfuma whispering to Scorpia. Those two are wrapped up in their own little world, leaving the four of them to chat. Catra's not really sure when Sea Hawk wandered off, honestly, she doesn't much care.

"So Catra." Glimmer says all false innocence. "Have *you* met your soulmate?"

"*Glimmer!*" Adora scolds, something like panic on her face.

"*Glimmer!*" Adora practically shouts, absolutely panicking. She can't believe her! It's like Glimmer threw her under the bus *and* somehow made her drive it over her own body.

"What? It's a perfectly normal question! Unless *you* had something to add *Adora.*" Glimmer challenges.

Adora sets her jaw stubbornly, keenly aware of Catra watching their exchange. "How about you just stop being so nosy *Glimmer*?" Infusing her words with all the subtext she can muster she adds, "Maybe it's not *up to you* to decide what is or isn't perfectly normal." The air between them crackles with hot intensity.

"Guys." Bow attempts to placate.

"Uh I don't know if this is gonna help or hurt, but I can answer the question."

Adora whips her head around, ignoring Glimmer's victorious, "Ha!"

"I haven't, met them I mean." Catra supplies nonchalantly. "Honestly, I'm not sure I buy into the whole soulmate thing." Adora shifts restlessly.

"What about Perfuma and Scorpia? Or Bow and I for that matter?" Glimmer questions her, ignoring Adora's warning glance.

Catra just shrugs. "I mean, I'm sure it's a thing and I know plenty of people find theirs. I just don't know I that I think it's worth waiting for, ya know? Like, why wait around for someone you may never meet if you could build a perfectly happy life with someone who just happens to have a different mark."

Truthfully, Adora feels rather the same way. Or has in the past. But then here's Catra, sitting like Venus emerged from the heavens, presented on her half shell. Adora doesn't know *what* to think now. She tries not to let her sinking heart color her reaction too much, scolding it for being so foolish. "Aw Wildcat!" Scorpia calls, apparently having tuned into the conversation. "I think you'll be happy no matter what, but there is something pretty cool about meeting someone who..." She trails off, getting briefly lost in Perfuma's eyes. Her eyes snap back to Catra when she clears her throat. "Right, sorry! It's just a little but different is all I'm saying."

"Totally agree!" Bow pipes up.

"Thanks Bow!" Scorpia leans over to bump his fist with her claw.

"What about you Adora?" Catra turns to look at her with a mischievous smile on her face.

Adora is saved from answering when Perfuma gasps. The group turns to look at her, a kale chip falling from her gaping mouth, as her eyes dart from Catra's chest to her face. She cuts her eyes to Adora and must see the panic there because she clicks her mouth shut.

"Adora, babe are you?" Adora shakes her head violently at the unasked question. "But...are you sure."

"Not right now Perfuma." She says, a note of finality to her voice. Perfuma looks unsure so she shakes her head again for good measure. Stars above, could her friends *be* any more obvious? She looks at Catra out of the corner of her eye, she looks totally lost. It's better, Adora supposes, that her catching on.

"Right...well Scorpia and I are gonna go walk along the shore."

"We are?" Scorpia questions, a note of confusion in her voice.

"We are."

"Perfuma..." Adora warns, questioning her friend's motive. Perfuma smiles reassuringly and circles the blanket to whisper in Adora's ear.

"Don't worry, Scorpia can keep a secret and we won't meddle, I promise. But for what it's worth...I think you should tell her. Catra can be a little...rough around the edges but she's a total sweetheart. I...actually can totally see how you'd suit each other."

"Whatever." Adora grumbles, saying nothing as she and Scorpia wander toward the shore.

"Am I...missing something?" Catra asks, looking around at the remaining friends.

"Nope!" Adora inserts before her friends can have their say, forcing herself to brighten. "Sorry, I think you got cut off before? You were saying something about not buying into the whole...thing."

"Nope!" Adora assures with false cheeriness that Catra chooses not to question. "Sorry, I think you got cut off before? You were saying something about not buying into the whole...thing."

"Right." Technically Adora was the one who got cut off, but she's being fucking weird so Catra isn't about to press. "I mean that's basically it. Sure, if I met someone with my mark, I'd be curious. I'm just not counting on it. Or investing energy in searching for it."

A little calmer Adora responds. "Yeah, that's pretty much how I feel too."

This seems to irritate Glimmer as she rolls her eyes forcefully. "But it's Adam," who responds. "It's a pretty big thing in Magicat culture though, generally speaking anyway, isn't it?"

Catra shrugs. She was raised by an abusive sorceress; she's not exactly super connected with her own culture. This guy probably knows about as much as she does honestly. "I guess, I think it's just the limited chances thing."

"Limited chances?" Glimmer questions.

"Yeah, nine, right?" Rainbow asks.

"Uh-huh, yeah if you don't find your soulmate in your first nine lives, you're like, doomed to be born without a mark. Cycling through lives for the rest of eternity." This news seems to cause Adora undue stress, she adopts a tortured expression and bites her lip. "Honestly, worst case scenario, who cares? Literally not my problem. And plenty of people are born without marks, our friends Entrapta, for example, doesn't have one. And I don't think I've ever seen someone care less about something."

"What about the flip side?" Bow! She's pretty sure it's Bow. Bow asks.

"What do you mean?"

"Like what happens when a magicat *does* find their soulmate?"

“Oh, so you and your partner keep your marks for your current and all future lives. You're supposedly incapable of *not* finding each other after you do so once. Then after nine lives spent together you enter like, heaven or nirvana or whatever, together with all the best parts of yourselves from all your past lives.”

“*Fuck*.” Adora breathes.

“*Fuck*.” Adora breathes. So, if she doesn't tell Catra... And if she *does* tell Catra... Adora's fairly certain humans are reborn with their marks indefinitely. At least, according to the legends. But if the magical cat legends are true—what if she's Catra's last shot at finding her soulmate with her mark still emblazoned on her chest?

Bottom of The Ninth

Nine
Catra & Adora

Five

As it turns out when Adora stopped being squirrely about their shared mark, she and Catra had gotten along famously. Her friends weren't exactly smooth about it, but she did appreciate it when Bow and Glimmer made excuses to wander off. It gave her a chance to talk to Catra without an audience which was a welcome relief. Before she had left, Catra had given Adora her number. "You know, just in case."

It had taken Adora a full twenty-four hours and multiple pep talks from Bow and Glimmer to gussy up and text her. Once she finally did, they'd barely stopped texting. Plus, they still saw each other on the bus most evenings. Catra had taken to just sending Adora a running commentary on her day. The other night she'd texted a picture of a box of Trix with the caption. Did they stop making these into shapes or can I just not see them bc I'm not a kid anymore?

Adora thought her response was hilarious, 'What are u talking about? Ur not a child? Coulda fooled me.'…

But either Catra got distracted or she didn't agree because Adora didn't hear from her again until the following morning. Adora had a text when she woke up that just said, 'Haha. Dummy.'

Now Bow and Glimmer are prodding her to take the next step. "Come on Adora! You can't just keep texting her forever!" Glimmer prods, pointing her chopsticks at Adora. The two of them plus Bow are out for dinner. Glimmer had pointed out that it's Friday night and they should be out on the town doing *something*. Glimmer had *not*

been impressed when Adora reminded her that it is actually her Thursday.

"Uh, can so. I like texting her! Texting is good, texting is *safe*, no one can see anyone's anything texting."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Adora basically all you wear are button ups, you're hardly at risk of accidentally exposing your mark."

"To be fair it is summer, and Adora wears *way* more bro tanks in the summer." Bow points out around a mouthful of noodles.

"*See!*"

Glimmer groans dramatically. "Not helping Bow! Stars alive Adora, just don't wear a bro tank when you hang out with Catra then. Problem solved." Adora just pokes at her curry and pouts.

Finally, after a few beats too long, she murmurs. "What if she says no?" She looks up at her friends with a pleading look. "I dunno if I can get rejected by my own *soulmate*."

"Adora, you know you have to tell her at some point, right?" Bow questions gently making Adora sulk in her seat.

"Well, yah. I just don't know when...or how. Ugh! It's not fair, how come I didn't take *my* shirt off first? Then this could be *her* problem." The server comes up to fill their water glasses as she laments this fact. They shoot the table a weird look as they walk away.

"Well you didn't so. You should probably ask her out already. And frankly, I'd be giving you the same advice, soulmark or not. You two are clearly into each other, resolve the sexual tension already!"

"Hy- *Glimmer!*"

"What?"

"I love you, you're also kind of the worst sometimes."

"No, you're just stubborn."

"I am not!"

"You're being stubborn Wildcat."

"I am not!" Catra screeches.

"Uh-huh." Scorpia says skeptically. "So tell me again; why haven't you asked Adora out yet?" She stabs her fork into the salad Perfuma had made them for dinner, not taking her eyes of Catra.

"Uh, did you ever think maybe I don't *want* to ask out Adora?"

"Yeah, no. I would do just about anything for you to take me half as much as you take her."

"Aw, Scorp, are you jealous? You know Perfuma is sitting right here." Catra teases with a snicker, gesturing to Perfuma who sits across from her.

"Oh, I don't mind!" She pipes up sweetly. "I know how much Scorpia loves you."

"Ugh, gross." Catra makes a face at them, which goes totally over their heads. Her tail twitches in agitation.

"Stop deflecting! Listen, all I'm saying is that you *clearly* like her. So, what's the holdup?"

"There's no holdup! Will you just butt out of my love life please?"

"Wildcat, we've known each other a long time. How realistic do you really think that is?"

"Why are you so annoying?" Scorpia just blinks at her, expression unchanged. "Ugh, fine, I like her. Are you happy?"

Scorpia grins widely. "Ecstatic! What are you gonna ask her to do?"

"Who said I was gonna do anything about it?" Scorpia's face falls and she just stares at Catra again. "Fine! Fine, if it'll get you to back off, I'm sure I can stand one date with Adora."

Scorpia's smile resumes. "Text her now!"

"What? Can I finish my food fi- "

"*Now!*" Scorpia demands. "I don't trust you not to go back on this later."

Catra rolls her eyes but pulls her phone out of her pocket to type out a text to Adora. U free Sunday? She turns her phone to Scorpia. "There, happy?"

"Very! What are you gonna do? Ooh! The mini golf place just reopened. Oh! Oh! Or there's that Italian place over of 55th"…

Adora's phone buzzes, vibrating on the table. She thanks the heavens, she's ready to be done with this interrogation. Her heart stops when she sees it's from Catra. Her friends are watching her and she's sure they can already tell who it's from based on her reaction alone. She slides the message open. U free Sunday?

"What did Catra say?" Glimmer asks smugly.

Adora, stunned, turns to show her friends the screen. She barely registers their excited squealing as she turns the phone back around to reply.

Yah, what's up?

Was thinking we should hang.'

“What did she say?” Glimmer demands, craning her neck to try and see over Adora’s phone. She’s much too short for that to be a realistic goal, but she gives it her best.

“Leave me alone! I’ll show you when I’m done.” Glimmer harrumphs.

‘Cool’
‘What did u have in mind?’

Catra doesn’t respond at first. Adora frets about it while she finishes her food. She’s still fretting about it as she hands the server her card, waving off Bow and Glimmer’s protests about her paying. Finally, *finally*, as they linger by their cars saying an extended goodbye, her phone chimes.

‘Whatever. We could grab like, lunch or something? There’s a new instillation going in at the art museum.’

‘Cool! I’m not picky’
She bites her lip, hesitating. She sends the message before she can think better of it. ‘We could hit the museum and grab food after if we’re hungry.’

‘Tight, wanna meet at EAM at like, 11ish?’

And that’s how Adora finds herself standing in front of the Etheria Art Museum on Sunday morning. She looks at her watch, it’s still ten till and she’s already been there for ten minutes. She just didn’t want to be late… She bites her lip and stands from the bench she’d plopped on to stretch. She scans the area around her and sits back down with a sigh. She pulls out her phone and starts playing some game. She’s distracted and loosing terribly. Suddenly she looks up.

Catra parks her bike and looks around her as she locks it up. Adora is easy to spot with her bright hair and bright red jacket. She’s hunched over slightly on a bench, poking at her phone. Catra

wanders over slowly, observing her. She's gorgeous, which Catra already knew, with her brow furrowed in concentration or frustration. Maybe both. Her toes tap to some unheard beat, then stop suddenly when she looks up. Catra can see the moment Adora registers her presence, standing quickly with a goofy wave.

"Hey Adora." She drawls once she gets close enough. "Thanks for meeting me here."

"Yeah, sure thing! I'm excited." Her eyes widen almost imperceptibly. "A-about the uh, museum. Art."

Catra laughs lightly. "Right, yeah I'm excited too." She pointedly doesn't clarify what she's excited *for or*. She leads Adora inside, it's the first Sunday of the month so their admission is free. Luckily, it's not too busy inside and they're able to wander through slowly. They start with the permanent exhibits. Catra's familiar with them but she enjoys following Adora around, exchanging commentary. Adora is cute, she gets so excited when she finds something she likes.

She stops in front of a glass sculpture and turns to Catra. "Ooh, I like this one." Turning back and gesturing vaguely to the piece she adds, "It's sos...woopy."

Catra laughs loud enough that another patron turns in her direction. She doesn't notice, or care. "That's one word for it." Adora chuckles and walks toward the next exhibit. She turns and walks backward to watch Catra, who laughs at her. "You know if you walk into some priceless artifact because you were being a dumbass, I'm not above pretending to not know you."

"Wow, vicious! And here I was thinking you might be ride or die material." She's grinning widely. Catra has to admit her coordination is like, astoundingly good as she seamlessly maneuvers around a bench.

She raises an eyebrow at her. "Yeah, maybe in other circumstance but I'm not about to get banned from the art museum for your ass. I

ride or die for myself before I ride or die for anyone else."

Adora halts, making Catra stop short in front of her, and her smile shifts from teasing to genuine. "That's pretty cool Catra. Some seriously good self-love shit."

Catra laughs and it pierces the quiet, hushed atmosphere of the museum again. "Glad you think so." She holds Adora's gaze for a moment longer than could be considered strictly friendly before wandering toward the nearest painting.

"Glad you think so." Catra holds Adora's gaze and she swears it makes her heart stop in her chest, the mark above it is burning pleasantly. Can Catra feel that too? Perhaps not, Adora thinks as she wanders away from her, toward the next piece of art. Her tail sways behind her and the movement mesmerizes Adora a little bit.

Adora drifts behind her through the next couple exhibits, enjoying her shifting expressions. She starts to catch on to how she responds to what. The face she makes when she loves something, when she really doesn't, and Adora's favorite; when she thinks something is really good but still absolutely *hates* it. Adora thinks she's never met someone so funny before.

Then her stomach starts grumbling, and though she curses it for doing so Catra just giggles. They wander down to a pizza place nearby and get themselves set up with some slices. "So," Catra begins as Adora shoves half a slice into her mouth. "I never asked, are you from Etheria or...?"

Adora shakes her head to buy time while she swallows. "Nuh-uh, Eternia actually."

"Gotcha, what brought you here then?"

"Hm, change, I guess."

"That' s vague."

Adora smirks. "Y eah, I suppose so. I dont know , there wasnt really anything back home for me. I met Glimmer when our teams played against each other in high school and we'd stayed in touch. I actually almost joined the army after high school. When I really thought about it though, I couldnt bear to sign up to fight battles I dont believe in. When Glimmer suggested I move here wellI didnt have anywhere else to go so."She shrugs. It used to make her sad, how little her life in Eternia amounted to when she left it behind. Things are different now;she has a family , a life. She's not so bothered now she has the perspective to see she wasnt running *away*, but rather running toward something better.

"Damn, well,"Catra catches Adora' s eye and she feels her cheeks heat. "I'm glad you ended up here."

"Y eahme too."She clears the emotion that' s lodged itself in her throat. "What about you?"

"Etheria born and raised Im afraid. I mean, I love my city butI do wanna see others someday."

"Y ou havent travelled much then?"

"No, could never af ford to."

Adora nods, able to relate. "Y eah, where would you go first then?"

"Mystacor ."Catra answers without a hint of hesitation. Adora smiles, that's at the top of her list too. She wonders absently if theyll ever make it there together. The significance of the thought doesnt hit her later, alone in her bed trying and failing to fall asleep.

Six

Catra and Adora grab dinner after Catra gets off one Monday after work. They've started hanging out pretty regularly over the last six weeks or so. Catra can't remember the last time she clicked with someone so well. Hell, she's not sure she's *ever* clicked with someone so well. After dinner neither had been in a rush to get home, so Adora had driven them just outside city limits. The sky is clear here and they sit in the bed of her truck, just watching the stars.

It doesn't escape Catra how very date like this situation feels. She doesn't ruin it by bringing it up. Just enjoys the warmth of Adora's arm against hers and the cicadas singing in the background.

"Hey Catra?"

"What's up Adora?" She blinks and looks down from the sky.

"Well I know we already talked about this when we met, well at the beach I mean."

"What's that?"

"Well soulmates"…

Catra rolls her eyes, but internally her stomach flips. It's something that she's thought about in passing since she and Adora have been hanging out. Not hers but Adora's. "What, you find yours since then or something?"

"I just, you said you don't buy in?" Catra notices the deflection but her flipping gut dissuades her from pressing it. She just shrugs, her ears flattening against her head. "What if you *did* find yours?"

"Like what would I do?"

"Yeah." Adora's voice is barely a whisper.

"Fuck I don't know. It's so hypothetical, you know? Like I'd definitely be curious, but I guess it's hard to know what exactly I'd do. Thinking about it it's just this amorphous blob of a person. It depends so much on who it is. And also, I mean, who knows if I'd even be available at that point."

"Do you ever imagine what they're like?"

"Mostly I just feel sorry for the poor sucker."

"*Catra.*"

"Geez, it's a joke! Why, you imagine what yours is like?" She turns to look at Adora and ignores her racing heart. "You said you're not into either, right?" She'd kind of been banking on that fact actually. But she also knew that plenty of people *say* they don't give a shit about finding their soulmate and then when they do things change. And change is the last thing Catra wants, so she stays cautious.

"I don't know. I feel...confused." Catra's heart stops entirely. What does that even *mean*?

"I don't know. I feel confused." It's the truth, just not the whole truth. The whole truth would be; *I feel confused because you're in front of me, but you don't know. And I think I'm falling in love with you and I wish you'd make a move or something, because I'm terrified and I can't tell how exactly you think of me.* But those words won't come.

"Confused?"

"Well, yeah."

"Adora," Catra groans, Adora sees her tail starts thrashing in agitation beside her. "You're the one who brought this up. Either get at whatever it is you're trying to say, or fucking drop it. I'm not dragging it out of you." Catra's words sting but Adora tries not to let it

show in her face. She's trying to figure out how to tell Catra, she knows she's waited too long already. Perfuma had words with her more than once. Perfuma's own soulmate respects Adora's desire to do it on her own terms but Adora knows she's putting Scorpia in a tough position. Catra's not making it any easier to come clean in this moment;infusing so much bite into her words.

"I just I get afraid. What if my soulmate doesnt like me, or doesnt like me like that? And how how do you even broach that topic? Like, the universe thinks we should be together , but do you? I dont know, it's stressful." She knows she should stop talking in hypotheticals, just come clean but…

"So, which is it Adora? Do you not buy into the whole thing or are you anxiously awaiting fucking Princess Charming coming in to swoop you off your feet?" Adora starts like Catra slapped her .

"What? That' s not what I- "

"I'm just saying you should probably figure it out sooner versus later . Or are you just gonna get careless with some poor shmuck' s heart? Date around like you dont care and then drop them the minute you meet your soulmate." Catra looks almost feral, Adora *knows* she's being shitty, but she also knows she doesnt deserve all of that.

"That' s not fair!"

"Isnt it? Come on Adora, you act like you're so above the whole thing but then you're sitting around fretting about some asshole you've never even met!"

"Okay , you're way of f base Catra. I'm actually trying- "

"No, I'm really not Adora! I might have some lingering curiosity but I'm not living my life waiting for someone who may never come. And if they show up after I'm already committed to someone else then that's their loss. Can you say the same?"

"That's really not the point I'm trying to make here Catra!"

"So, then what exactly are you trying to say? That you *led,* you actually do give a shit? Stars, I'm so fucking stupid! You're just waiting for them, aren't you? You think you're not gonna wait, but if you had the chance to go for it with someone with the wrong mark you couldn't do it."

"That's totally irrelevant Catra. What I'm trying to say- "

Catra laughs bitterly. "Of course it is." She starts clambering out of the truck bed, leaping over the side. "Take me home Adora."

Adora scrambles after her. "Wait! Catra, no I- "

"*Take me home*" Catra grits out through clenched teeth, her ears still flat.

Adora stares at her; her hand is waiting, poised on the handle of the truck's door, jaw set stubbornly and fury in her eyes. Adora's not really sure how the situation devolved to *this*, but she lets it drop with a sigh and hops in on the driver's side. The ride Is silent. Adora thinks about just exploding with the truth, making Catra listen. She just doesn't exactly seem receptive right now.

When they reach Catra's building Adora idles in front for a minute. Catra doesn't make any immediate moves to jump out of the car like Adora thought she would. She decides to try one more time, maybe she can still shoot her shot. Softly she starts, "Catra I'm so sorry. I- " Catra bursts out of the truck without a word, leaving a gaping Adora in her wake.

"Catra I'm so sorry I- " Catra gets out of the truck without a word, she can't hear whatever Adora is about to say. She's not sure if Adora figured out why she's so upset on the way over and is about to let her down easy. Or maybe she's just apologizing because she can

tell Catra’s upset and it’s in her nature to try and smooth things over. Either way nothing Adora could be trying to say can stop Catra’s heart from breaking.

Seven

Adora hasn't heard from Catra in weeks. She's tried, over and over again she's tried. Her texts go unanswered, calls are rejected, insta directs left on read. At least she isn't blocked. So, she doesn't have her hopes up about this evening. Perfuma and Scorpia are hosting game night, she knows Catra is invited. Perfuma *claims* she'll definitely be there. Adora's just going to wait and see.

She's not there when Adora arrives with Bow and Glimmer. She's not there after the first three rounds of Uno. She's not there duri-

"What's up nerds, you better not have played Pictionary without me." Catra's voice calls from the entryway. Adora's heart stops, fingers reflexively going to check that her top shirt button is still firmly clasped. It is, she undoes it and redoes it anyway. Just in case.

"Catra!" Scorpia calls back, bounding over to the entryway from her place at the dining table where she's been fussing over and replenishing snacks. "We sure didn't, but what's going on? I was getting worried! Why are you so late?"

"Ugh, Weaver made me stay late to finish a project. She's probably not even gonna use the final product, I'm pretty sure she was just doing it to be a-" Catra rounds the corner into the living room and freezes when her eyes land on Adora. "-a bitch. Uh, hey Adora. Um, everyone." She clears her throat loudly.

Adora figures being greeted directly is a good sign and abandons her cards and the group she was playing with to walk over to Catra. "Hey Catra. Um... how have you been?" Scorpia's eyes dart between them and she opens her mouth as if to say something. Seeming to think better of it she shakes her head and sidles away. Catra barely notices and Adora shoots a strained smile her way as she goes.

"Yeah, it's been fine." The silence between them stretches awkwardly. Adora can feel the less than covert glances their friends keep shooting her way. "Have you had a tour?"

Adora startles, not what she was expecting, but she'll certainly take it.

"Yeah, it's been fine." Catra has no idea how to fill the silence that stretches between them. She can tell that Adora is growing restless under the watchful eyes of their friends. They need to get out of here. "Have you had a tour?"

"Ohuh... I mean I saw the bathroom."

"Well then you've seen the highlight, but why don't I show you the rest?" Adora barely manages a nod before Catra grabs her hand and drags her out of sight into the hallway. "Right, so bathroom." She points to the first door on their left right as they hear the faucet shut off. Mermista wanders out and eyes the two of them and their clasped hands.

"Tour!" Adora erupts, voice high and tight.

"*Right…*" She lifts a brow, her expression the picture of boredom. "Well enjoy that."

She wanders off and Catra snickers. "I really do like her." Without a further thought Catra points at the door on their right. "Entrapta's room, known for small explosions at two in the morning." A few steps further and she points to the second door on the right. "Scorpia's room, which she and Perfuma live in maybe thirty percent of the time these days." They reach the end of the hall and the door directly ahead is the only one Catra bothers to open, pulling Adora through.

She doesn't say anything as she watches Adora look around the room. It's nothing extraordinary; a bed, dresser and book shelf sit

around the room. There are more clothes scattered around than if she'd planned for this and a sloppy stack of records sits at the base of her dresser. She walks over to the player and restarts the same album she'd been playing that morning.

"Sowho' s room is this?" Adora teases.

Deadpan, Catra replies, "Melog' s." It' s not even a lie really.

Adora's face scrunches up all cute and confused. "Who?" Then, with a voice still creaky from sleep, Melog emerges from the bed with a meow. Adora gasps dramatically. "How have you never told me you have a cat?" She drops to the floor and sticks out her hand. "Hey bud, I like your room. My name's Adora, and you must be Melog." Catra watches fondly as Melog looks back at her as if to gauge her reaction before going to sniff Adora's fingers. In practically no time at all she has the cat flat on his back, purring loudly. Catra goes to sit on his other side, across from Adora.

"W ell look at you two, making friends and shit."

"Catra, he' s such a cutie!"

"Eh, he' s alright." At Melog' s accusatory look she amends, "Y ou know I love you, you furry little shit." Adora' s laugh is clear and bright, it makes Catra think of Christmas time.

With nothing else to talk about the silence returns. Adora finally breaks it, bless her. "So"…

"So."

"I havent heard from you in a while."

"Y eah."

"I'm not really sure what I did wrong at this point." Catra looks up from Melog into Adora's eyes. She looks too tired to be sad, Catra's chest clenches with icy guilt.

"I-I'm sorry . I don't think I even know anymore." It's a lie, she does know. She just also knows it wasn't fair . Adora couldn't read her mind, didn't know how she felt. Didn't know that bringing up her soulmate sliced Catra open, that everything she said after was just salt in an already burning wound. "I shouldn't have ignored you. At first, I was still mad about whatever . And then"…

"And then?"

"I felt embarrassed, overwhelmed; I didn't know how to explain myself."

Adora regards her seriously for a moment. "I don't think I was entirely fair to you that night either. I was being pushy and vague."

Catra shrugs. "Not an excuse."

"No, but still; I'm sorry too. Can we just put this behind us?" She gives Catra a pleading, hopeful look.

"I'd like that." Catra of fers her a small, reassuring smile. "I want us to be friends." Adora gives her a weird look, she hopes it isn't because she can see exactly how Catra feels about the word *f riends* .

Adora shakes off whatever is on her mind and smiles back tentatively, Catra can't help but think it still looks a little sad. "Right, friends."

The A side of the record finishes shortly after. They listen to the b side before rejoining their friends, catching up and making plans to resume where they left off. To resume their *f riendship* .

E ght

Adora is buzing. T oday is the day, it *has* to be. She cant bear to keep the truth from Catra for a minute longer. She's telling Catra about her markth eir mark, today . And abouthow she feels. She wont miss another opportunity . She gets to Catra's stoop and rings the buzer . There's a crackling and then, "What?"

"Ooh!So charming."

"Shut up, are you here?"

Adora rolls her eyes. "No, but Im on my way , be there in twenty."

"Gat see you then, okay , *by*e ."

"Catra!"Adora laughs indignantly .

"Can I help you?"

"Y eah, get your cute butt down here and take me to the park."

A silence and then. "Y ou think I have a cute butt?"

"Et down here and maybe Ill dignify that with a response."Catra' s laugh gets cut off partway through. Adora taps her foot and eventually starts scrolling through Instagram while she waits. Catra bustles out the door a little more than five minutes later while Adora is in the middle of a video about a foster kitten getting rescued and adopted.

"Hy Ad- "

Adora is misty eyed and not even a little embarrassed about that. "ook at this *kitten*."She sidles up to Catra and tilts her phone her way. When it finishes, she looks up at Catra who is looking not at the

phone, but at Adora herself. She has a fond smile on her lips and shakes her head slightly.

"You're an idiot."

"Hey!"

"So, I think this should be a date." Catra blurts.

"- *what*?"

"Yeah, just to be clear about my intentions; I think this should be a date." She scratches the back of her neck, looking a little bit shyer. "I uh- well I hope it's okay but I have feelings for you. Gay ones, specifically."

Adora grins widely. "Oh." Then she remembers the very key piece of information she has to share and her grin slips. Catra should probably know before they talk any more about… *feelings*. "-I, Catra I have to tell you something."

"Well that doesn't sound good." Catra chuckles nervously.

"It's well, just please don't be mad. I should have said something sooner; I *know* I should have said something. But." She can't force the words out. She sighs, resigning herself, and reaches to start undoing her button up.

"Adora! What the *fuck* are you doing?" Catra screeches, looking around the block to see if anyone else is watching this. Adora doesn't answer, just undoes the next button with a shaky breath. Catra's eyes dart to her chest and back to Adora's face. Adora sees the moment something registers; her mouth pops open slightly, her eyes open wide as saucers and tears spring into her eyes. "No, no way."

Adora doesn't answer, just undoes her fourth and fifth buttons with shaking hands. She freezes, looks Catra in the eyes, and panics. Is

she really ready for this? She thinks so, she has to be, has already reached the point of no return but… Catra reaches over and brushes her hands away, peeling back the sides of Adora's shirt and revealing her mark. She stares at it for a minute, the seconds creep by as slow as molasses and just as syrupy sweet. Her tears spill over when her eyes flit up to Adora's.

"I can't believe it Adora you- you *fucking* asshole!"

Adora ignores the tear she feels sliding down he nose, dripping from the tip, onto her top lip and into her mouth. "I-I know, I'm sorry." She sits on Catra's stoop, cradling her head in her hands. Catra leans against the low concrete wall that serves as a railing and looks down at her.

"Shit, you must have known since…what? The fucking beach?"

"Yeah." Adora murmurs, her eyes glued to the step below her feet.

"So, why didn't you say anything? And why tell me *now*? After I- after…fucking *her* Adora!"

"I *know*, I know and I'm sorry! Can I just, can I explain, please?" She turns her head to look at Catra with a pleading look.

"I certainly think I deserve an explanation, so go right ahead." Catra's arms are crossed over her chest.

Adora nods a couple times than resumes her staring contest with the concrete step. "Right, yeah. Well I…you're right, of course. I saw at the beach and I didn't say anything because, well, truthfully I was freaking out." She laughs humorlessly. "I never really counted on finding my soulmate honestly. And when you said you felt the same way about it I just felt…it weird being like, 'Oh yeah by the way, I'm yours though.'… And then I don't know I…started to like you and I just wanted to pretend." She trails off, attempting to gather her thoughts.

"Pretend what?" Catra's voice cracks a little bit and when Adora chances a glance her way she's looking off into the street.

"I wanted to imagine what it would be like withoutwithout the mark. I wanted to know if you'dlike me even if you didn't have to."

Catra scoffs and this time when Adora looks up she's staring right at her. "I don't *have* to like you Adora."

"You know what I mean." Adora presses.

Catra's eyes roll. "Whatever. Sure, I get what you're saying but it's still fucked up you knew *for months* and didn't say anything."

"I know, and that's totally fair. Can I ask though, what would it have changed?"

The look Adora receives is sharper than the edge of a sword. "What the hell does that mean?"

"It means-it means if I *had* told you, what would have happened? You said you don't have to like me, and that's true. But it would have colored your opinion somehow, right?"

Catra looks caught off guard by the question but she also looks like she's genuinely considering it. "How the hell am I supposed to know?" Or maybe not. "Yeah, it probably would have made some kind of difference but…"

"So, what about now?"

"What *about* now Adora?"

"Well, you told me you have feelings for me we're soulmates… what happens next?"

Catra's face flushes red and a flurry of emotion passes over her face; anger bleeds into frustration bleeds into embarrassment bleeds right back to fury. "Well Adora, not sure if you realized this but you

still havent said fuck all about how you feel. Youre all worried about how me knowing will affect how I feel. Then here you are, and youve known *the entire time*, so I guess I dont fucking know Adora. Do *you* even like *me*? Not me your soulmate but me Catra. Did it even fucking occur to you that I might have some of the same insecurity about this soulmate shit?"

Catra cant believe what she's hearing. What, Adora wants *her* to answer that question? Catra's said her piece, made her little… confession or whatever. Adora's the one who decided to wait until *now* to drop this little bombshell. And now she wants Catra to gather the pieces and present them to her on a platter? Fuck that. "Well Adora, not sure if you realized this but you still havent said fuck all about how you feel. Youre all worried about how me knowing will affect how I feel. Then here you are, and youve known *the entire time*, so I guess I dont fucking know Adora. Do *you ever* like *me*? Not *my soulmate* but *me* Catra. Did it ever fucking occur to you that I might have some of the same insecurity about this soulmate shit?"

Oh."

"You're an idiot." Catra pities this version of herself, scoring on the weather.

I know sorry. I'm sorry Catra. I just didn't know, there's no fucking guidebook on how to handle this conversation. But I do… I do have feelings for you. I'll work it into a heist and be done with it."

Catra asks the first thing that comes to mind. "So, what would you have done if you hadn't?"

"Sorry?" Catra rolls her eyes.

f you had had f eelgs W you ever told e? Ctra' s terrif ied of the answer as soon as the question is out of her mouth. She' s not really sure what the right answer is. She' s not even sure if there is a right answer . Heck, she' s not even sure what she' s so worked up about anymore! Is this a good thing? They both have f eelgs f or each other and now he does have to worry about Alora' s late swooping in three years down the line, f uckig up their hit. Although, Ctra hates that she f eels ked to, she f eels like Alora made some kind of f ool of her . Then again, that' s not really Alora' s f ault. She sighs and drops down to sit next to Alora, who still has n't answered. "Well?

Probably . I don't know how I would have ever had that conversation, but I think I f eel to guilty knowig and keaig you in the dark to keep it to yself if it only ." Ctra nods, that does actually make her f eel a little better .

Sorry I f ew of f the handle. You just surprised me A lot do f eel a little weird about the f act that you know f or so log bef ore you told me. But the sentiments can't say I would have handled it any dif f erently ."

Back at Alora bookshop of fice

Ctra sighs. "Yeah, I guess it' s really f ucked weird. The whole situation is f ucked weird. You' re right; there is no guide book."

Right, well, in the interests of f uture disclosure" Alora starts, Ctra makes a gesture to encourage her to continue. "I have f eelgs f or you but" Ctra tenses "they are hugely romantic." Alora gestures here and there f toward Ctra and suddenly her hands are full of Ctra, him and f lowers. Ctra looks down at the bouquet in his hands and then back up at Alora, who is looking at him with a soft smile on her face. "Will you be my boyf riend?"

Nine

Alora lay half on top of Cora, tracing the lines of her mark. It's been months now that she's been allowed to do this, and she still loves it. The lines, so familiar to her own, ebb and flow over her lover's chest as they breathe. She pops a piece of bok choy from her mouth.

Finally, she's awake. Alora thought so but they've been lying out in the park by the lake, and Cora's been in the same position with her glasses on for at least twenty minutes now. Her breath had begun to even out a little while ago, so Alora was sure.

"You ever wonder which life you'd be on?"

Cora raises her head and lifts her glasses to get a better look at Alora, before she cranes her neck without lifting her head to make eye contact. "What the fuck are you talking about?"

"You know, like you told me at the beach, about magical fork bros. What if I was your last chance?" Alora bites her lip but Cora rolls her eyes and lays back down.

"That's illegal," she said a bit, "there's no way to ever know if it's true. Let alone what life you'd be on. Could be one life for all I know, we probably had plenty more chances to find one another."

Alora knows her nerves are audible when she responds, "I really freaked out you know."

"I really freaked out you know," Cora lifts to lean against the lift in Alora's torso, her ears perking up.

"What did I babe?"

Aora boks back down at their ank ore Ctra' s chest. "Ithat I.. cold f ok sethig as bad f or yf. or you. Ul had, wel hav e reay , this f eelg ingt"

Ctra ove to it pop erly and Aora lif ts with her , ettig her ad drop between them. Aora hol s in her own "Wat f eelg."

"Ithat this you ith. Tat if.. I cold get it together f or yf. or you, d be rig ou as ot."

"Hy ." Ctra waits til Aora boks pa gain. "W e're good, we did it. Fr s If e, ith If e- it does atter . f we're goig by agic at bre we've got a gara teed eterity ahead of s"

Aora ies swarly n . "Y eah," She ighs "Tat' s pretty cool"

"Y ou're an idiot." Ctra teases f ondly . Ther s a ear in f or a kis ad is set half way . Tis kis is as warm and at isfyg as all the others. A il, even now , just like ever y other tie it ights Ctra p lke it' s the f ir st time. She f eels their ark swarig ad thik, not f or the f ir st tie, that are eterity of this ond s pretty dam perf ect.

End Notes

I find these soulmates identifying mark stories so interesting, so Im exited to take a stab at it!Part 2 should be out relatively soon.

Also Im on twitter now as @logoblens!
I dont totally get it yet but Im really just there to retweet SPOP , Dragon Prince and ATLA stuff. So, if thats your vibe, come find me so I know who to follow for that good Catradora ish.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!